THE SEA GYPSIES

an original screenplay by

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FADE IN:

EXT. NORTH ATLANTIC - SEAFLOOR - NIGHT

Black. Absolute.

A pulse of light — soft blue — blinks in the dark. Another answers. Then dozens, the rhythm passing from one to the next like a signal down a wire.

In their glow: a seamount, cracked and steaming. Vents breathe columns of superheated water into the cold.

A line of pipe runs off into the darkness, north — section after section, pieced together from the hulls of sunken ships. Portholes. A stenciled hull number. A name plate, half-legible. The oldest sections are crusted with years of growth. The newest still show bare, rusted steel.

The lights gather along the pipe, drifting, pulsing. Whatever they are, they never quite take shape.

A final section of hull, a faded waterline still painted on its side, settles over the largest vent. Nothing visible guides it. Only the light, swarming around its edges. Metal grinds against rock.

A brighter pulse — gold, deliberate — ripples outward. Every light goes still.

The seal locks.

The vent's plume disappears into the pipe. The line shudders, then hums, as superheated water surges north through miles of darkness.

The lights scatter and are gone.

EXT. SPACE - INTERNATIONAL SPACE STATION - NIGHT

The ISS glides along the curve of the Earth. Below, the North Atlantic lies dark and still.

INT. INTERNATIONAL SPACE STATION - CUPOLA - CONTINUOUS

A FLIGHT ENGINEER, 30s, floats at a thermal-imaging display. The ocean renders in cool blues — until a thin red line draws itself across the screen. Straight as a ruler. Running north.

FLIGHT ENGINEER
Houston, ISS. I've got a thermal anomaly, North Atlantic, off New England. It's linear. Repeat — linear.

HOUSTON (V.O.)
Copy, ISS. Stand by.

Static. A long pause.

A DIFFERENT VOICE (V.O.)
ISS, be advised. That sector is restricted. Log it as sensor drift.

The engineer looks at the red line a long moment. Then types: SENSOR DRIFT.

SMASH CUT TO:

EXT. PORT OF HAMDEN, MASSACHUSETTS - DAY

The docks of Hamden are bustling with activity as fishing vessels of all shapes and sizes prepare for their next voyage. Nets are hoisted by huge cranes; sailors swab the decks, rinsing them clean in a mist of saltwater spray.

Dodging his way through the throng of fishermen is RICHARD "FLASH" GORDON, 26, who, while clearly not a bookworm, has a studious sensibility to his overall appearance and demeanor. He carries a bright orange case, emblazoned with a lightning bolt design, which swings precariously as a counterweight to the heavy duffel bag strung across his back.

He sets his course down the long dock toward the end of the pier where THE CALLISTO, one of the older but well-maintained fishing trawlers, is moored.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - CONTINUOUS

Muffled angry voices can be heard coming from the bridge of the boat as two FISHERMEN make their way down the gangway to the bulkhead of the pier. They swing their duffel bags over their shoulders so they can better count the crumpled bills in their hands.

FISHERMAN ONE
Jesus... what a trip. That's a week of my life I'm never gonna get back.

FISHERMAN TWO
Way too far out, if you ask me. There's a point where you stop chasing fish and start chasing your own funeral.

FISHERMAN ONE
At least we made it back. Wasn't always a sure thing, the way he was pushing us. He was pretty tough.

Flash approaches the bulkhead and makes his way to The Callisto.

FISHERMAN TWO
Tough but fair. Paid us in full even after a bad haul like that. Some captains wouldn't have. That's one thing I heard about Captain Marius. He's a real stand-up guy.

The fishermen go back to counting their money as Flash looks to squeeze by them.

FLASH
How's it going, guys?

FISHERMAN ONE
It's going well but if you're headed up to The Callisto, keep walking back the way you came. Not a whole lotta action on that boat.

FISHERMAN TWO
Ah, don't scare him off. Every greenhorn has got to start somewhere.

FLASH
Hey! I'm no greenhorn!

FISHERMAN TWO
No? Well, you surely don't look like no fisherman either.
(shrugs)
Suit yourself.

The fishermen continue their way down the pier. Flash watches them, looks up at The Callisto, shrugs his shoulders, and continues on his way to the waiting boat.

The muffled voices grow clearer as he gets closer — a loud, angry argument.

INT. THE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Holding court is CAPTAIN WILLARD MARIUS, 59. His well-worn uniform complements his sun-weathered skin and graying beard. He sits perched on his command chair, formidable and stoic. On the back of the chair is a stylized embroidered naval crest with the names "Annika" and "Agnetha" evident in the design.

The cabin is clean but faded with age, like Marius himself. Awards crowd the walls, along with photos of Marius with a pretty blonde woman and a young girl who resembles her.

DYLAN (O.S.)
I always liked this photo. Aggie must have been, what, about eleven here?

Pointing to one of the photographs is DYLAN CARTWRIGHT, 32, slight but athletic, dressed in a sharply tailored suit that looks conspicuously out of place against the Callisto's faded interior. Despite the wealth and privilege suggested by his clothing, there is a trace of humility in his manner.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
She was ten. Always tall for her age. Same as her mother, rest her soul.

Marius reaches for a cigarette; a faded tattoo of the same crest design is visible on his right forearm.

DYLAN
I'd have thought you would have given those up years ago, Willard, especially knowing—

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Knowing what? And it's Captain Marius to you, at sea or in this godforsaken port you call home.

Before Marius can even light the cigarette, Dylan walks over and promptly takes the cigarette from him, tosses it and the whole pack into the trash.

DYLAN
Knowing what I know is all I meant. And yes, Hamden is my home. Whatever you think of me or my family, I've done my share of time on the open sea.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
The hardest you ever worked was hoisting a tray of caviar and champagne on that preposterous yacht of yours.

DYLAN
Look, Will—

Marius gives Dylan an angry glance, evident even through his thick beard.

DYLAN (CONT'D)
Captain Marius. Let's leave the personal out of it. This is business. The Callisto.

Marius reaches into his desk, pulls out another pack of cigarettes and lights one up.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Sure thing, Mister Cartwright. Say what you came to say before I have you keelhauled for trespassing on board my boat.

DYLAN
It may be your boat today but it's tomorrow I wouldn't be too sure of.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - CONTINUOUS

Making his way to the bridge is JONAS WILLIAMS, 62, a large, solidly built Black man wearing faded military fatigues. His weather-beaten, deeply lined face is dominated by a remarkable smile that seems permanently etched into it.

Jonas hears the muffled conversation, glances down at Flash waiting on the dock, and shakes his head wearily before knocking on the door.

JONAS
Excuse me, Captain!

No reply. He knocks again, firmer.

JONAS (CONT'D)
(through the door)
Captain?... Captain Marius? Don't mean to interrupt, but the new deckhand's here and—

CAPTAIN MARIUS (O.S.)
Not now, Jonas!

Jonas turns to go as the door flies open and Dylan Cartwright tries to rush out of the bridge, only to be pulled back in.

DYLAN
JONAS! Thank God! The Captain—

CAPTAIN MARIUS
You're not going anywhere yet, Dylan! We're not done here!

Marius sits back down in his chair as Dylan finds safer haven on the other side of the bridge.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (CONT'D)
Sorry, Jonas. Welcome our new deckhand aboard while I finish up here.

The door of the bridge slams shut as the heated conversation continues.

INT. THE CALLISTO - BELOW DECKS - LATER

Jonas escorts Flash through the bowels of The Callisto, giving him a tour, passing through the various decks of the boat.

Flash peers around, taking it all in, struggling to fit his gear through the tight passages.

JONAS
This should all be somewhat familiar, most trawlers are pretty much the same give or take a thing here or there.

FLASH
(tentatively)
Oh, sure. You've seen one, you've seen them all.

They arrive at the crew quarters and Jonas motions to the many empty bunks.

JONAS
You can have any which one you want as we're not quite sold out today.

Jonas takes the heavy duffel bag as Flash carefully puts down his orange case.

JONAS (CONT'D)
C'mon, there's plenty of time to get settled. I got some things to take care of but let's go find Gary. He's probably down with the girls. He can take it from here.

FLASH
Sure. Who's Gary?

JONAS
Gary? He's the master of all things Callisto. If I didn't actually know his real mama, I'd swear this boat gave birth to him itself.

FLASH
You mentioned his girls. Does he have kids?

JONAS
Kids? No—
(chuckles)
But as far as Gary's concerned, those girls are the only family he's ever needed. Spoils them rotten.
(MORE)

JONAS (CONT'D)
Try telling him different, see how far you get.

Jonas laughs at his own joke as they both continue deeper into The Callisto.

INT. THE BRIDGE - LATER

DYLAN
We can't extend any more credit, Captain. The returns just aren't there.

Dylan says it like a man reading from his father's script.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
And neither are the fish. For now.

DYLAN
It won't change, and you know it. This isn't a dry spell. The bank's carried you longer than any reasonable return would allow.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
So that's it? We just give up? I'd sooner scuttle her than turn her over to you — OR WORSE, YOUR FATHER!

DYLAN
Can't you just leave my father out of this? Not everything is about him.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Everything is about him! I thought better of you, but now you've become nothing more than one more disappointment.

Dylan rolls his eyes, motions to Jonas to intercede.

The side door of the bridge opens quietly and GARY MEADOWS, 35, enters, unnoticed. He is slight of stature with even smaller muscles, but his hands are large, with strong, noticeable tendons. A permanent smear of grease streaks his forehead. There's no mistaking him for an accountant.

DYLAN
Please, Jonas, you're a reasonable man. Can you understand the position we're in?

JONAS
Truthfully, Dylan, I've never understood the position you're in.

Jonas gives Marius a firm look. The Captain eases off.

JONAS (CONT'D)
This is more than spreadsheets.
If we don't fish, we die.
It's simple arithmetic.

DYLAN
I'm sorry. We can't fund another trip. The well's bone dry.

GARY
(interrupts)
But the fuel tanks aren't.
This should cover one more trip.
We can top them off before we sail.

Everyone turns to face Gary, who hands Marius a thick, worn envelope.

GARY (CONT'D)
Sorry, Captain, I couldn't help overhearing. You're not scuttling anything.

Marius opens the envelope, which is stuffed with cash.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
I can't take your money, Gary.
We'll find another way.

Marius hands the envelope back to Gary, but he refuses to take it.

GARY
From what I heard, there isn't another way. Besides, it's not for you, it's for the girls. I was saving it to buy Thelma and Louise a little something.
They'll understand.

JONAS
Why, you little devil. Where'd you come up with money like that?
It sure as hell isn't your poker skills.

GARY
Let's just say, I'm a man of few needs and material possessions.

JONAS
What you really mean is you still live at home with your mother.

GARY
I'll ignore your snide innuendo. She's a remarkable woman and a helluva cook. Nothing wrong with a home-cooked meal every now and then.

Gary turns to Marius, serious now.

GARY (CONT'D)
You've always done right by me, Captain. Let me do right by you.

Marius nods with understanding as his eyes well up some. He puts the envelope in his pocket, looks squarely at Dylan.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
See that, Cartwright. That's a real bond between men that you'll never understand.
(to Gary)
Son, I won't ever forget this. Not ever.

DYLAN
Fine. Fuel for one more trip. And where are you going to fish that you haven't already?

CAPTAIN MARIUS
We'll manage.

DYLAN
Not without another deckhand. And, more importantly, a licensed navigator.

A knock at the door breaks their attention for a moment.

GARY
Sorry, that must be the greenhorn. I kinda forgot about him.

Gary moves toward the door, opens it and looks surprised.

Standing before him is AGNETHA "AGGIE" MARIUS, 26, her hair tucked beneath a baseball cap, an oversized jacket concealing the slight woman beneath. She removes the cap, revealing strong features that clearly recall her mother's, then slips out of the jacket, becoming one with the waiting crew.

GARY (CONT'D)
Miss Marius?

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Agnetha!

DYLAN
Aggie?

JONAS
Welcome aboard, Aggie.
Welcome home.

AGGIE
I hear you're in need of a
navigator, so here I am.

CAPTAIN MARIUS AND DYLAN
Absolutely not!

Aggie puts her jacket aside, walks over to Marius and gives him a slight kiss on his cheek, which melts his heart, but he remains steely silent.

AGGIE
Hi, Dad. It's nice to see you too.

Aggie looks over to Dylan, gives him a cold and acknowledging look.

DYLAN
It's nice to see you again, Aggie.

Aggie ignores Dylan, makes her way to Jonas and gives him a warm hug, which catches him off guard but is welcome in so many ways.

AGGIE
Now, about that navigator job.
When do we sail?

CAPTAIN MARIUS
We don't. You know where I stand on
this. Nothing's changed.

AGGIE
From what I've heard, everything
has changed! Dad... Sorry, Captain
Marius. I have to do this.
You need me—

CAPTAIN MARIUS
What I need is for you to march back
off my bridge, off my boat and go
home.

AGGIE
I am home!

JONAS
(clears his throat)
Perhaps it's best we get Miss Marius settled. Gary, show Aggie to her quarters.

AGGIE
Thank you, Jonas, but I prefer to bunk with the crew.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Now hold on here. No daughter of mine is bunking with the crew. Not on my boat. You'll sleep in your cabin. That's an order!

AGGIE
Aye... aye, sir!

JONAS
We're still short a deckhand.

Everyone turns to face Dylan Cartwright.

AGGIE
Are we?

Aggie stares Dylan down, tempting fate.

DYLAN
Me? I'm no... I mean...

CAPTAIN MARIUS
I think that's a splendid idea!
(sarcastic)
Besides, what better way to protect your investment? Kinda keep a look on things firsthand. Make sure we're keeping you honest.

Jonas leans into Aggie.

JONAS
I'm not so sure this is a good idea. That boy has never really been out to sea. He's still weaning off his mother's teat and—

Aggie waves her hand at Jonas to cut off his further remark.

AGGIE
Careful, Jonas. I'd leave it at that.

Jonas raises his hands in surrender.

JONAS
Sorry, what was I thinking?

AGGIE
Besides, he just might surprise us. How bad could it be?

EXT. THE CALLISTO - NEXT MORNING

The Callisto makes her way out of the port of Hamden and into the open seas. At first the water is calm, but the farther the ship gets from shore, the rougher the waves become.

BEGIN MONTAGE

-On the bridge, Marius takes the helm as Aggie works the navigation console.

-Jonas puts the new deckhands, Dylan and Flash, through their paces in full safety gear.

-The Callisto rolls through rough swells. Dylan bolts for the rail and throws up.

-Down in the engine room, Gary tends to Thelma and Louise.

-Aggie walks the deck, eyeing Dylan from afar. He bolts for the rail again, heaving an "aero-barf" into the churning sea. Aggie chuckles.

-The seas settle as the setting sun stretches long shadows across the deck.

END MONTAGE

INT. THE BRIDGE - EVENING

Marius sits alone on the bridge of The Callisto and takes a long drag from his cigarette, staring out at the darkened sea that lies ahead.

Far ahead, a thin veil of mist rises off the black water — on a night with no fog in it. Marius exhales. His own smoke drifts across the glass. When it clears, the mist is gone.

INT. CREW QUARTERS - EVENING

Everyone is gathered around the small table, finishing their meals, except for Dylan, who is snoring peacefully.

JONAS
Good work today, everyone. I have to admit, even Dylan surprised me. He might have the makings of a fisherman yet.

AGGIE
Nothing has ever surprised me when it comes to Dylan.

Aggie clears the dishes, motions to the sleeping Dylan.

AGGIE (CONT'D)
He's probably the only one who's never been this far out from shore.

FLASH
Actually, I've never been this far out either. First time for me too.

AGGIE
Where are you from?

FLASH
North Dakota, if you can believe it. MIT for grad school. Now I'm drowning in student loans like everybody else.

AGGIE
(a small laugh)
Welcome to the club. Try paying off a loan on a teacher's salary.

FLASH
You're a teacher?

AGGIE
Marine biology, Miami.

Aggie washes the dishes as Flash dries them. Jonas heads topside to check on the Captain.

AGGIE (CONT'D)
Closest I can be to the ocean without being out to sea. Of course, Dad... I mean, Captain Marius, would have preferred that I actually teach kindergarten in Boston, but that's not going to happen. We're too much alike.

INT. CREW QUARTERS - LATER

Gary and Flash are chilling in their bunks. Aggie brings over some cold beers, hands one to each of them.

FLASH
Are you sure this is okay?

AGGIE
Just what the Captain ordered. Drink up, boys, because after this we'll be in for the long haul.
(winks at Gary)
Salud!

They all clink bottles.

Gary looks over to Flash's bunk, sees the orange case with the emblazoned lightning bolt.

GARY
Hey, Flash! What's with that orange case?

Flash jumps off the bunk, takes the orange case and places it on the table.

FLASH
Just some cool stuff I saved. Here, take a look.

Flash opens the case and takes out some antique, odd-looking electrical equipment, including a small TV contraption and various vintage radios and meters.

Flash singles out a particular radio with a multitude of dials and knobs, along with a vintage microphone attached to a coiled cable.

FLASH (CONT'D)
From what I've seen so far, The Callisto looks like it's been keeping up with electronics and looks pretty state-of-the-art. So, I bet you haven't seen one of these before.

AGGIE
What is that thing? Some kind of radio?

FLASH
(proudly)
It's more than a radio. It's a high-frequency transceiver utilizing ionospheric propagation for unrestricted transmissions.

Aggie and Gary look at each other, perplexed and not understanding a word that Flash just said.

Flash turns on the radio. A general hum emanates from the receiver, with various other squeaks audible through the speaker.

Flash makes one final adjustment with a satisfied grin, speaks into the microphone.

FLASH (CONT'D)
November Alpha One Sierra Sierra. November Alpha One Sierra Sierra. This is Kilo Two X-ray Oscar Mike. K-2-X-O-M calling the International Space Station. Do you copy? Over.

After a few seconds of static and some frequency noise, the radio speaker light activates and the voice of COMMANDER BRONSON, 40s, crackles through.

COMMANDER BRONSON (V.O.)
(very formal)
Kilo Two X-ray Oscar Mike, this is November Alpha One Sierra Sierra. Read you loud and clear aboard the ISS.
(friendly)
Is that you, Flash? Long time no hear, my friend. Over.

FLASH
November Alpha One Sierra Sierra, yes, this is Flash. How are you, Commander? Over.

COMMANDER BRONSON (V.O.)
Can't complain, given the view.

A groggy Dylan wakes up and makes his way to the group by the radio.

DYLAN
What's going on?

AGGIE
Shhh!
(whispers)
Flash is talking to the space station from his radio.

DYLAN
Really? That's interesting.

GARY
(mimicking Flash)
It's a high-frequency radio transceiver.

DYLAN
Oh, you mean a "ham radio"? We have one of those on Dad's boat but we upgraded to new satellite phones. We kept it because it looked vintage. That's pretty old school, though.

GARY
Old school or not, Flash is talking to an astronaut! How cool is that?

AGGIE
Well, I'll leave you boys to your toys and head topside. I need to check the bearings for the night before turning in.

Aggie grabs her jacket, makes her way out of the crew quarters.

AGGIE (CONT'D)
Don't stay up too late. We have some serious work ahead of us. Good night, gentlemen.

INT. THE BRIDGE - LATER

Navigation charts are spread out on the chart table as Aggie checks the course of The Callisto. She takes careful measurements with a ruler and compass.

Marius peers over her shoulder with some concern, his hovering presence becoming an annoyance.

AGGIE
Dad... Captain, you don't need to hover over me. Could you just give me some space? I got this.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Oh, I know that. Just making sure—

AGGIE
You don't have to make sure of anything. That's my job and it's a good thing I checked.

Aggie puts her ruler and tools down.

AGGIE (CONT'D)
You had the destination plot points set through the North Atlantic G-P-Z, so I made the adjustment and recalculated the course.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Oh, I hadn't realized that. Do you think we need to do that? It's gonna cost more in fuel and that'll limit time to actually trawl. We have precious little time and fuel. Wouldn't want to waste it.

AGGIE
How could you ask such a question? You know better than that.

Aggie grabs the rough and weathered hands of Marius in a tender manner.

AGGIE (CONT'D)
What's going on, Captain...
I mean, Dad?

Marius looks defeated.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Nothing... nothing's going on.
I'm just a bit tired, that's all.

Marius releases his grip, makes his way to the charts, looking them over as if he is acknowledging Aggie's calculations, but that's far from his mind.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (CONT'D)
You are so right. I did teach you a thing or two. I'm glad you're here, Aggie, but I really wish you didn't come.

AGGIE
Why would you say that?

CAPTAIN MARIUS
I honestly don't know.

Marius pushes the tools, the compass and the charts out of the way.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (CONT'D)
I think I need a smoke, or better yet, a peaceful night's sleep. Too many dreams. All gone.

Aggie eyes him suspiciously and with some concern.

AGGIE
I'll program the coordinates into the GPS and set the autopilot, for now. Be back shortly. You have first watch.

Aggie programs the coordinates, sets the autopilot and heads out of the bridge.

INT. CREW QUARTERS - CONTINUOUS

With boyhood fascination, Dylan and Gary move closer to Flash and the radio.

FLASH
You know... you still owe me for that thermo final.

COMMANDER BRONSON (V.O.)
(chuckles)
You can never let that go, can you? An undergrad kid tutoring a senior Navy pilot. But it definitely saved my G.P.A.!

FLASH
Copy that. Hey! How's the view up there tonight? Anything worth reporting for us poor souls stuck on this godforsaken rock?

COMMANDER BRONSON (V.O.)
Water temps in the North Atlantic are running higher than anything in the historical record. Whole thing looks like it's running a fever.

FLASH
(chuckles)
Well, send some our way. It's freezing out here.

COMMANDER BRONSON (V.O.)
Careful what you wish for. Talk soon, Flash. Kilo Two X-ray Oscar Mike, this is November Alpha One Sierra Sierra, out.

The radio clicks to static. Flash shuts the radio off, smiles proudly at his crewmates.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - BOW OF SHIP - NIGHT

The sky is an inky black color, with millions of brilliant stars illuminating the darkness.

The ship bobs up and down as The Callisto slices through the slight waves. The bridge is illuminated in a dark amber color; the silhouette of Marius holds watch over them.

The navigation lights bathe Aggie and Jonas in shades of green and red as they stand by the railing looking out over the darkened sea ahead. Their waterproof parkas are wet and glisten from the spray of sea foam as the ship journeys forward.

JONAS
Your dad never had much luck asking for help. Bank included.

AGGIE
What happened?

JONAS
(carefully)
When your mom got sick, the insurance didn't last. He put the boat up as collateral. Went to the bank himself.

AGGIE
And?

JONAS
Prescott Cartwright turned him down flat. Didn't even look up from his desk.

AGGIE
(bitter)
Of course he did.

JONAS
Cold as they come. To him, your dad was just a number that didn't add up. Same way he treats his own son, if you want the truth.

Jonas looks at the water instead of at her.

JONAS (CONT'D)
Wasn't till he was walking out
(beat)
that the son caught up to him in the parking lot.

AGGIE
Dylan gave him the money?

JONAS
Called it a gift. Behind his father's back, and it cost him. Prescott found out, near disowned the boy over it. Called him weak. Like "throwing money to the wind." Dylan never backed down.
(beat)
But by then it was already too late to matter. Not for her. And the boat went back to the bank — on Prescott's terms.

AGGIE
Dylan never told me that.
But then again, we haven't spoken much. Not for a while.

JONAS
(carefully neutral)
That's a conversation for him to have with you, not me.

AGGIE
Jonas?

JONAS
All I'll say is, whatever this boat owes the bank on paper, it owes that boy a lot more underneath it. Your dad knows it too, even if he'd never say it to his face.

Aggie studies him. There's something else in him.

AGGIE
What aren't you saying?

Long pause. His jaw tightens.

JONAS
Your mother fought hard, Aggie. Harder than anybody should have to. But there's a difference between fighting a sickness and fighting to still want a tomorrow.

A long silence. Aggie doesn't ask him to finish the thought. Some part of her has always known better than to make him say it out loud.

JONAS (CONT'D)
(quiet)
Your dad's never forgiven himself for not seeing it coming.

AGGIE
(barely a whisper)
Neither have I.

Neither of them says anything more.

Aggie looks up. Something in the sky doesn't sit right with her, though she says nothing.

INT. THE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Marius, alone on the bridge, checks on the coordinates. Once everything is verified, he disengages the autopilot and enters a new course.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - BOW OF SHIP - CONTINUOUS

Aggie stands at the rail, eyes fixed on the sky, anywhere but on Jonas.

Far off the bow, just beneath the surface, a few pairs of soft blue lights glow in the black water — evenly matched, unblinking. Jonas follows her gaze upward. Below, the lights sink away into the dark.

Aggie inhales deeply, eyes closed a moment.

AGGIE
I'm not a person who likes land too much. It's too still. Too complicated.

JONAS
(a low chuckle)
Only you would call dry land complicated.

Aggie glances at him. This isn't just a man enjoying the view.

AGGIE
You sleep better out here. I've noticed.

JONAS
(a half-smile, not quite a joke)
Land's got too much quiet in it. Gives a man time to think.

He doesn't explain further. He doesn't need to.

JONAS (CONT'D)
Your dad's the one who figured that out about me before I did. Fresh back from the sandbox, both of us — me all the way from Kansas, of all places. He didn't say much about it, just showed up one day, said he was taking me fishing. First week, I was seasick, blistered and sure he'd lost his mind.

AGGIE
And then?

JONAS
(quieter now)
First night I actually slept, out here, rocking on that water, best sleep I'd had in over a year. Didn't tell your dad that for months. Didn't have to. He already knew.

Aggie looks at him differently now, not just a family friend, but something closer to family, period.

AGGIE
That's why you never left.

JONAS
That's why neither of us did.

He looks out at the dark water, the old ease returning to his shoulders.

JONAS (CONT'D)
Some men come back from a war and can't find solid ground again. Your dad found me an ocean instead. Turns out that worked better anyway.

They stand in silence a moment, the ship's wake the only sound.

JONAS (CONT'D)
(quiet)
"Let the water under the sky be gathered to one place, and let dry ground appear."
(beat)
"And God saw that it was good."

AGGIE
Genesis?

JONAS
Don't look so shocked. A man can know scripture and still curse like a sailor. Out here you start looking up more than you look down. Read that verse enough nights like this one, you start to think whoever wrote it spent some time on a boat.

Aggie regards him a moment. There's more to Jonas than the war stories and the easy grin.

She looks back up, still not quite ready to meet his eyes, and stops. Her gaze catches onto something in the sky, tracking it without meaning to.

AGGIE
(quiet, to herself)
That's not right.

JONAS
What?

AGGIE
We should be running due east by now. We're not.

She's already moving toward the bridge before Jonas can respond.

INT. THE BRIDGE - MOMENTS LATER

Marius sits by his console, entering something in the logbook and checking his bearings on the navigation screen.

Aggie barges in through the door.

AGGIE
Dad! What are you doing?

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Aggie! What's the meaning of this? Don't you knock? Even you can't just—

AGGIE
You changed the course! Didn't you?

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Excuse me? And watch your tone. Daughter or no daughter, I'm still the Captain here.

AGGIE
Why'd you do it?

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Do what? I don't know what you're talking about!

AGGIE
I can read a map!

CAPTAIN MARIUS
You set the heading yourself, what makes you think I—

AGGIE
The stars, Dad. I don't need a navigation chart to tell me where we're heading when the stars will do just fine.

The Captain is at once proud and embarrassed he got caught.

AGGIE (CONT'D)
You taught me that. YOU! Now you come clean, and I mean right now!

Aggie tries to gain some composure as Jonas joins them.

AGGIE (CONT'D)
You purposely changed the heading back through to the North Atlantic G-P-Z and—

JONAS
WHAT! Willard? What the hell?
You know we can't go there.
The G-P-Z is a red directive sector.
We all know what that means.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Oh! Relax. We'll be in and out of
the zone before anyone even realizes
it.

JONAS
They'll put us in jail, that's what
they'll do, or even worse. That's
if "The Gypsies" don't get us first.

Marius laughs heartily, catching them all by surprise.

AGGIE
Gypsies? I don't understand.
I thought the area was just
government-protected waters and to
be avoided for some sort of security
reason.

JONAS
(slowly)
G... P... Z.
(faster, letting it
run together)
G-P-Z. Gee-pee-zee. Geepeezee...
(letting it land)
Gypsies. Say it enough times in
enough bars, that's what you get.
Boats go in there, boats don't come
out. Old-timers swear it's the
Gypsies that take 'em.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Oh, it's government waters, all
right. Jonas here is just being
superstitious, that's all. Nothing
more than tall tales by drunk
sailors in a two-bit dive bar.

JONAS
You can laugh at me all you want,
but either way we don't belong
there. Rules are rules.

Jonas looks a bit hurt at the accusation.

JONAS (CONT'D)
(quiet, almost pleading)
This boat's the only solid ground I've ever trusted, Captain. I'm not in a hurry to find out what happens to a man like me if we lose her.

Marius walks over to the table with all the navigation charts and devices.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Take a look. At the current speed and direction, we'll be in the sector by morning.

Marius shows them his map projections and calculations.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (CONT'D)
We'll try our luck fishing a bit. If it's a bust, I promise we'll leave by noon. As long as we kill the A-I-S and maintain radio silence, nothing should give our position away before anyone is the wiser.

The navigation charts identify the restricted area, which is labeled NORTH ATLANTIC GYRE PELAGIC ZONE, and in bold red letters: "GPZ - OFF LIMITS."

AGGIE
I don't know, this seems really wrong.

JONAS
It's more than that. It's stupid, that's what it is.

Jonas points to the highlighted zone on the map. His hand has a slight tremble to it.

JONAS (CONT'D)
And dangerous, if you ask me.

Jonas slams his hand down on the map to make his point.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Well, no one's asking you!

AGGIE
DAD! Uh, Captain Marius... you can't be angry with Jonas. He's the First Mate and has a right to ask questions.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
I know what he has a right to.

Marius stares Jonas down.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (CONT'D)
Any questions,
(sarcastically)
First Mate?

Their eyes meet, suspiciously, and for the first time in their friendship, there is a clear threat between them.

JONAS
No, sir! Orders are orders.
But off the record, Willard...
(catching himself)
Captain. I hope I'm wrong.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - MORNING

The sun is peeking over the horizon. The clouds are drenched in brilliant hues of color.

The ocean waters are fairly calm; white sea foam rises from the bow as The Callisto cuts her way through the crests of waves and slight swells.

A few dead fish drift past the hull, belly-up and pale, as if poached. The bow wave rolls them under.

INT. CREW QUARTERS - MORNING

The crew is finishing their breakfast. Jonas calls down from the stairs, alerting them to be topside in five minutes.

Dylan takes another swig of the distasteful mess in his cup that passes for coffee.

Gary leans back, takes a swig of coffee, too relaxed for comfort.

DYLAN
Hey! Aren't you coming?

GARY
Not today. Got a date with Thelma and Louise. But you better hurry, greenhorn!

JONAS (O.S.)
DYLAN! C'MON, MAN! LET'S GO!

Dylan gives Gary a dirty look, grabs his jacket and hurries up the stairs.

INT. ENGINE ROOM - LATER

The engine room is cavernous, at least by the standards of a boat the size of The Callisto. Although the expanse is filled with a multitude of pipes, ductwork and wires, it is spotlessly clean with nary a speck of dirt or dust.

Marius is calling out to Gary through an opening between some pipes.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Just make sure there are no issues whatsoever, Gary.

GARY (O.S.)
Captain?
Have there ever been any issues from the girls? Ever? The answer is no. And there won't be today either.

In the center of the space, two large engines, one blue, the other red, purr in a perfect mechanical harmony. On the blue engine cover is a plaque with the name THELMA embossed in bright chrome letters. The red engine has a similar plaque with the name LOUISE, shiny and bright.

Gary comes out from behind the pipes, lovingly wipes down some of the industrial components in front of him.

GARY (CONT'D)
See, Captain. The girls know you're here and are on their best behavior.
(to the engines)
Aren't you, girls?

Marius looks at the three of them and chuckles.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
You know, Gary, sometimes I just don't understand you. You seem almost in love with them, more than I've ever seen you with a real woman.

GARY
No more than you with The Callisto.

Marius smiles and nods in agreement.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
(the words don't come easy)
What you sacrificed for them... for The Callisto. I don't forget that, Gary.

GARY
You always call me when something's broken. Just once, I'd like you to call me because something matters.

Both men look at each other, a moment of silence only they can understand. Gary nods as a slight tear wells in his eyes.

GARY (CONT'D)
We'll just go back to work, right, girls? Things to do, you know, and...

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Just as well. I'm gonna head up to the bridge. Duty calls.
(winks)
We got some fishing to do!

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - LATER

Jonas, Flash and Dylan are busy preparing the deck, checking that everything is secured, awaiting the word from Marius to deploy the fishing nets.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - CONTINUOUS

Moving across the open seas, The Callisto passes a series of red warning buoys floating in the water, marking the territory of the off-limits GPZ. Some are painted with a red diamond and the word "*DANGER*"; the nearest has a diamond and cross symbol, with a flashing red warning beacon atop. The words "*RESTRICTED AREA - KEEP OUT*" are a not-so-welcome sign to what lies ahead.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - CONTINUOUS

The loudspeaker on the deck comes to life as the voice of Marius draws their attention.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (O.S.)
Listen up, gentlemen. We're in uncharted waters here and about to start our first run! Time is of the essence, so let's make it count!

The engines of The Callisto rumble louder as the ship picks up speed. A slight wisp of smoke is visible from the sleek smokestacks of the ship.

DYLAN
Jonas, what does he mean by uncharted waters?

Jonas turns away, avoiding Dylan's inquiry.

DYLAN (CONT'D)
Jonas? I saw those buoys. Given the circumstances, if anything happens to this boat, I'm as liable as he is. Probably even more at risk.

JONAS
Look, I wouldn't give it another thought. I know Captain Marius better than anyone and he's no fool when it comes to The Callisto.

DYLAN
At one point in time, I might have believed you.

Dylan walks away, unconvinced but with little choice.

JONAS
(whispers to himself)
At one point in time, I might've believed me too.

INT. THE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Marius looks over at Aggie, who sits by the navigation console, checking data and telemetry.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
How's it look, navigator?

AGGIE
As good as it's going to get. We're here anyway. Let's do this and get the hell out of Dodge, while we still can.

Marius grabs the microphone.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Deploy the nets! Let's go fishing!

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - CONTINUOUS

Jonas stands by the controls of the winch, directing Flash and Dylan to assist here and there.

The net slowly deploys, spreading out behind the boat, fanning broadly before weights carry it down below the ocean surface, disappearing into the abyss.

The Callisto slows down a bit, then lurches as the nets drag against what feels like the seafloor.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (O.S.)
Jonas, pull the nets up a bit. I think we're scraping bottom.

Jonas works the winch on the right, motions for Flash to pull up on the left winch. The cables tighten, then stabilize.

INT. THE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Aggie keeps an eye on the sonar and monitoring screens, taking careful notice of some of the telemetry readings.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
How's it look over there, Aggie?

AGGIE
Fine, for now. The depth rose dramatically for a brief time then tapered back down. Hard to tell what would have caused that, but we're good. For now.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - LATER

The Callisto makes her way across the open sea, but down below, beneath the waves, is where the action is, as the nets cast a path far and wide above the seafloor.

Jonas keeps a lookout on the trailing nets. The winch cables groan, pulling taut.

JONAS
(calling up to the bridge)
WE GOT FISH!

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - LATER

Jonas and Flash slow the winches as the net is hauled into the rear of The Callisto. It is heavy and filled with writhing fish, trying to escape the confines they are trapped in.

JONAS
Now that's a catch!
(to Dylan)
Open the tanks in the hold, we got precious cargo here.

DYLAN
Aye, aye, sir!

They are joined by Marius and Aggie.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
I almost forgot what a great catch looks like.

JONAS
Guess your gut was right about this spot after all.

Marius gives Jonas a familiar look, acknowledging their long friendship without words.

AGGIE
Look, this is fantastic but we shouldn't spend more time here than necessary.

DYLAN
What do you mean, "than necessary"?

AGGIE
Not your concern.

DYLAN
It is now my concern, if it concerns this boat.

Aggie walks away, makes her way to the bridge.

DYLAN (CONT'D)
(to Captain Marius)
What is she talking about?

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Nothing that another good haul won't fix.
(to the crew)
Let's go, boys! We got some fishing to do.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - LATER

The Callisto continues to haul in net after net, each heavier than the last. Dylan watches from the rail, doing the math on what's filling the tanks below.

INT. THE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Aggie keeps a watchful eye on the telemetry and scopes, mapping their course across the GPZ area.

Marius comes over, peers over Aggie's efforts on the nautical charts.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
You're keeping busy.

AGGIE
None of this area has ever been documented, at least from any nautical chart I've ever seen. It makes sense to at least keep track of things.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
A few more runs, then we pack it up and head home. Promise.

Marius gives Aggie a tender kiss, far prouder of her than he's ever been. It feels right having her here despite his own reservations.

He is making his way out of the bridge when The Callisto lurches to starboard, tossing him to the deck.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - MOMENTS LATER

The Callisto rights herself quickly and continues forward, though the engines strain.

Jonas calls up to the bridge. Aggie runs out, almost trips over her fallen father.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
What the hell was that?

JONAS (O.S.)
CAPTAIN! I think we hit something!

Jonas joins them up by the bridge.

INT. THE BRIDGE - LATER

The three gather around the sonar, looking for any clues of what would have caused the ship to roll to one side so violently.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
The water's clear way below the surface except—

AGGIE
There. Some kind of undersea formation — maybe an old seamount. Drops off, then rises again, right where we hit.

JONAS
Or we probably took on more weight from the fish and we bottom-trawled something we shouldn't have.

Marius nods in agreement as Gary joins them on the bridge.

GARY
Captain? What's going on? All of a sudden Thelma started to really strain to keep up with Louise. I never saw that happen before.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
How are the engines now?

GARY
All good, as far as I can tell.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Okay, see to them. I want those girls ready to dance!
(to Jonas)
Have the crew pull in this last catch and secure the boat for the trip back.

Marius looks over to Aggie.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (CONT'D)
Plot us a course home. Let's not wear out our welcome.

AGGIE
I like the sound of that.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - LATER

The ship's crane strains and groans as it hauls the last catch of the day from the rear of The Callisto toward the tanks in the hold. The nets bulge and stretch with the large volume of fish held within.

Jonas uses the winch to lower the net to the deck. The net spreads out so Flash and Dylan can sort the fish, saving what they plan to keep in the main storage tanks.

JONAS
C'mon, guys! Step it up! Once this last catch is saved in the tanks, we're home free!

As they clear out the net, a mechanical hand of some sort juts out from beneath the mass of writhing fish. They both jump back, startled, and hesitantly approach this metallic apparition.

Flash looks closer, a bit more intrigued than Dylan, who runs to get Jonas.

DYLAN
Jonas! Come quick!
There's something in the net.

JONAS
There should be. They're called fish, in case you don't know that by now. Unless, of course, you hauled me in a mermaid. Now that would be something.

DYLAN
No, this is something really different. You need to see this.

Jonas follows Dylan to the net. The mass of fish flips and flops about. Dylan points to the mechanical hand.

DYLAN (CONT'D)
See that? It's a hand!

Jonas peers closer.

JONAS
Son of a gun. You're right! Hey, Flash! Give me that pole and let's see what's underneath.

FLASH
Well, I'm curious as can be.

Jonas and Flash pull the fish away from the mechanical hand, further exposing what lies beneath.

JONAS
Well, I'll be damned.

Marius and Aggie join the crew on the fishing deck, careful to step around the net that still contains some wriggling fish, desperate to return to the sea or succumbing to the air around them.

Their attention is drawn to what else lies in the net.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
What in God's name...?

AGGIE
It looks like some kind of old-fashioned diving suit.

Lying fully exposed on the deck, in a somewhat tangled position, is what looks like a mechanical man, covered in dirt, seaweed and a bit of flotsam and jetsam.

Its arms are tubular, with some sort of coil embedded within. The legs are similar in design, with various vents and protuberances.

The body is broad with a heavy glass circular shape in the center of its chest, surrounded by four smaller circular features. On its back is a circular aperture with openings at the bottom.

The most compelling feature is its head, which is made of a dome of reinforced metal, protecting a spherical device that mounts a series of lenses.

Whatever this is, it has been through some heavy-duty wear and tear, with dents, scrapes and scratches covering almost all of its parts.

DYLAN
Do you think someone's dead inside?

FLASH
Don't be silly. There's no one in that thing.
(wide-eyed)
It's not a suit.

Flash reaches down to the mechanical man, brushes away dirt and sand from its chest, uncovering a badge with a faded number: 3-6-9.

FLASH (CONT'D)
It's a robot!

Marius squats down near the mechanical man, freeing its heavy arm from where it was positioned. Its hand is clutching a corroded steel shard.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
And what's this?

DYLAN
It looks like part of a boat.

Aggie takes hold of the shard, runs her hand over it — rusted, pitted, worn smooth in places by years underwater.

AGGIE
(contemplative)
Whatever ship this came from, it's been rotting down here a long time.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - LATER

Dylan and Flash continue to work away, stowing the gear as the ship makes its way through open water toward home.

Propped up on the forward deck, in a somewhat comical pose, is the lifeless mechanical man, a sort of ship mascot keeping watch over relatively nothing.

DYLAN
You know a thing or two about electronics. What do you think that thing is?

FLASH
Nothing I've ever seen. Old, though. And heavy — it practically pulled the nets to the bottom of the sea.

Flash lingers a moment, eyeing the mechanical man. Something about it won't let him go.

INT. THE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Marius looks over the deck of the ship, its bow bouncing slightly to the rhythm of the ocean.

Aggie and Jonas sit at the navigation console, checking various readings and the course of the ship.

JONAS
How much time do you think, Aggie?

AGGIE
About fourteen hours. We traversed farther in than I thought we would have.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Well, with fishing as good as we got, how could we not?

JONAS
I don't think we've ever come close to what we just caught. It's the mother lode, for sure.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
I just knew things would turn around. They just had to.

The Callisto struggles in the water; you can feel the strain through the superstructure of the ship.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (CONT'D)
Hmmm... Something doesn't feel right.

He reaches for the ship intercom. Jonas heads down to the engine room.

INT. ENGINE ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Gary is frantically working by the blue engine; something is obviously wrong.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (O.S.)
What's going on down there?

GARY
I don't know yet! Thelma's going south, AND QUICKLY!

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - CONTINUOUS

With a deep metallic grinding screech, the ship shudders violently to the port side, throwing Flash and Dylan to the deck.

INT. ENGINE ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Smoke is billowing out of some of the engine components as Gary works to address the problem.

Jonas joins him.

JONAS
What do you think it is?

Gary keeps working, puts his tools down as the smoke clears.

GARY
I know what it isn't.
It's not Thelma.

JONAS
Well, that's good, right?

GARY
Yes and no.

The intercom light illuminates. Jonas walks over and activates the external microphone and speaker.

JONAS
Jonas here, Captain!

CAPTAIN MARIUS (O.S.)
Well? I'm sure you both felt that.
I need a status report, and I need
it now!

GARY
It's me, Captain.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (O.S.)
Damn it, Gary! You assured me the
engines would be fine. I trusted
you and those girls of yours.

GARY
I know, but it's not the girls.
Oh, sure, Thelma's been a bit rough
around the edges, and Louise is not
faring much better, but it's not
them.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (O.S.)
Then what else could it be?

GARY
(hesitantly)
Seems like both shafts are fouled.

JONAS
Are you sure? We're in open waters.
That makes no sense.

INT. THE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Stand by. I'm coming down.

Aggie is at the navigation console.

He throttles the engines down.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (CONT'D)
Aggie, you have the conn.

AGGIE
Okay, Dad. See what you can do. I really don't like this.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Neither do I.

Aggie looks over at the corroded shard, now resting on the chart table. Dread settles over her.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - EVENING

The ship remains still in the water, resting under the setting sun and the last light of day.

Near the bow of the ship, Dylan leans over the deck rail, slowly dragging on a cigarette. He glances over at the mechanical man, a lifeless presence of metal.

AGGIE (O.S.)
If you don't mind, I'll have one of those.

Dylan turns, looks over to see Aggie standing there, pulls out a cigarette from an almost-empty pack.

DYLAN
Sure, but I thought—

AGGIE
That I wouldn't smoke because of what happened to my mom?

Aggie readily takes the cigarette. Dylan lights it for her.

AGGIE (CONT'D)
(sardonically)
Well, it certainly wasn't cigarettes that killed her.

Aggie takes a deep draw of the cigarette.

AGGIE (CONT'D)
Why didn't you tell me that you gave my dad money for my mom's treatments?

DYLAN
A lot of good that did anyway. What difference would it have made? Besides, I didn't do it for you or "*for us*."

Dylan takes a deep draw, exhales quickly.

DYLAN (CONT'D)
I did it because it was the right thing to do. For your mother. It wasn't about scoring points. Besides, you were already long gone by then.

AGGIE
I'm sorry, you know that. I thought I had no choice. I had to leave.

DYLAN
Really, Aggie? No choice? You <u>had</u> to leave? Just like that?

AGGIE
It was "*complicated*."

DYLAN
Well, that's an interesting way of putting it. Complicated?

Dylan turns away from her, then turns back to face her.

DYLAN (CONT'D)
(quieter)
Your father, my father. Neither one makes it easy, do they?

Aggie nods, acknowledges the sentiment all too well.

AGGIE
(a tired, small laugh)
No. They don't.

Something shared passes between them, unforced.

DYLAN
I'm not sure what happened. I thought we had something going, you and I. Maybe even a future together.
(slightly patronizing)
You would have wanted for nothing.

AGGIE
There was nothing I wanted. It was never about your money, Dylan. I just don't know.

DYLAN
I do know. It's "complicated."

Dylan looks away as Aggie takes hold of his hand. It's not a particularly loving grasp, but it still conveys an unspoken bond.

AGGIE
Well, here we are.

DYLAN
Yes. We are certainly *here*.

Both look out across the deep blue ocean. The stars come out, brilliant without a moon.

A slight mist rises from the water like an evening fog.

INT. THE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Marius is holding court with Jonas and Gary.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
It doesn't seem likely we would have thrown a prop, just like that.
(stares Gary down)
It must be the engines.

GARY
It's not the girls, sir.
I'm positive. Something's fouled both shafts.

JONAS
Either way, we're not going anywhere until someone gets under there and takes a look.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
First light, then.

Gary nods, makes his way out of the bridge.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - BOW OF SHIP - CONTINUOUS

The mist thickens and condenses, surrounding the boat in a concentrated layer of fog.

Within the robot, a steady rhythm of mechanical pulses commences, like a heartbeat — not random, but patterned, repeating, deliberate. A signal with nowhere to go.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - LATER

Without warning, the sea around The Callisto churns violently, bubbling as if coming to a boil. The fog above the water surface intensifies.

The Callisto is floundering in the turbulent waters.

Aggie and Dylan are thrown to the deck, landing hard on the wet surface, their limbs flailing for support.

AGGIE
Dylan!

DYLAN
Aggie, stay down! I'll be right there. Hold on to whatever you can!

As they gather themselves, a piercing cry breaks the mood.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - CONTINUOUS

A volley of rusted metal — hull plating, rivets, a twisted porthole frame — pummels the deck. One particular piece slices Gary's upper arm, cutting him severely.

GARY
HELP! Something hit me!

Gary staggers by, holding his bleeding arm, trying to traverse the pitching deck to get below and to safety.

Hearing his cry for help, Flash opens the cabin door, helps the wounded Gary to safety.

INT. THE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

The lights of the bridge flicker and flutter; loud klaxons of emergency alarms are heard throughout. Warning lights flash on every control panel.

The violent lurch has thrown both men to the floor. Jonas helps Marius to his feet.

Marius and Jonas peer out the windows of the bridge, their eyes widening in disbelief at the sight in front of them. A low-lying fog covers the sea and parts of the lower decks.

A towering geyser of water and steam erupts from the ocean, like a pressure cooker releasing its contents, dwarfing and drenching The Callisto.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Oh my God!

A second geyser erupts on the other side, followed by a series of others, blasts of water that batter the ship on all sides.

The rolling motion of the ship is severe, but with the propellers inoperable there is no respite from the frenzy.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - CONTINUOUS

Each soaring gusher of water rains back down upon the ship, drenching it in a misty cloud of brine and sea foam.

After stumbling about, Dylan reaches Aggie and helps her regain her footing on the slippery deck.

DYLAN
Just hang on to the railing as best you can. I'm not sure we can make it to the lower deck just yet.

AGGIE
I'm not even sure where that is. I can't see a thing through this mist. It's also burning my eyes.

DYLAN
It's the saltwater spray.

Dylan wipes her eyes.

DYLAN (CONT'D)
I wish I knew what's happening! The fog is so thick, I can't see a thing past a few feet of the boat.

INT. THE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

The sirens and warning signals blare, relentless. Marius grabs a navigation tool and rams it into the last speaker until it sputters and dies.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
What do you think is going on? We're helpless in the water without the props.

JONAS
Mark my words, we're under attack.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
It seems that way but from who? Pirates? Russians?

JONAS
Remember where we are.

Marius stares out the windows. The geysers are less frequent, tapering off.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
(contemplative)
The Navy?

JONAS
And they'd rather sink us quiet than explain why this place exists. Where no one should be.

Marius gives him a withering glance.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Well, that changes things a bit.

INT. CREW QUARTERS - CONTINUOUS

Flash tends to Gary's wound the best he can, given the perpetual violent movements of the boat.

FLASH
Sorry. I'm better with circuits than skin.

GARY
It's fine. Do whatever you can. We have to get to the bridge and see what the Captain wants us to do.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - CONTINUOUS

The Callisto is battered in a fury of saltwater spray, making it difficult to get one's bearings.

Looking for any opportunity to cross the pitching deck, Dylan and Aggie try to make their way to safety.

They pass the robot, unaware that it is slowly powering up, moving its stiff mechanisms that have been clogged with dirt and age.

DYLAN
The blasts are slowing down. When I say run, follow me and hang on to my jacket.

AGGIE
Right behind you.

DYLAN
One... two... three... RUN!

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - CONTINUOUS

Electrons flow freely through the wires of the robot, energizing it with current and power. It moves slowly at first, loosening the joints that have been stilled for so long.

The cover of the optical lenses twirls open, revealing a light within. The lenses rotate and spin, as apertures inside move to gain focus and adjust to the dim light.

With great effort, the mechanical man struggles to rise into an upright position, only to be slammed back down as a large wave crashes over the deck. It tumbles across the deck in an awkward ballet of flailing arms and legs, landing with a heavy thud as another jet of water blasts upward.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - CONTINUOUS

A sudden and extremely powerful geyser erupts directly below The Callisto, pitching the bow up at a dangerously steep angle.

Dylan and Aggie claw their way across the deck. The bow hangs at the top of its climb — then The Callisto drops.

The descent is so abrupt that the boat plunges beneath the waves, covering the deck completely. Dylan holds on desperately, but Aggie is sent sprawling and is lost in the bedlam as another geyser buffets the boat.

DYLAN
AGGIE!... AGGIE!

When the boat settles, Aggie is nowhere to be seen.

Dylan calls out over and over to no avail.

DYLAN (CONT'D)
HELP! ANYONE! AGGIE WENT OVERBOARD!

EXT. THE CALLISTO - LOWER DECK - LATER

The chaos that ensued has abated dramatically as The Callisto floats quietly on the calmest of oceans, flat and virtually motionless. Under a moonless sky, brilliant stars reflect back in the water, like a mirror.

The crew is gathered at the stern of the ship, tending to Aggie, who is shivering from the cold air and her completely drenched clothes.

Marius drapes a thick blanket over her, trying to comfort Aggie as best he can.

AGGIE
I honestly don't know what happened.
(teeth chattering)
All I remember is running across the deck when one of those water blasts hit The Callisto.

DYLAN
I know. I didn't expect that.
The whole ship almost disappeared.

AGGIE
That wave knocked me completely down and I guess dragged me over the rail.
(to Dylan)
Thank God you were able to save me. I'm not sure how you even dived into that ocean. It was so scary, but—

DYLAN
Aggie... I... uh... I didn't.

AGGIE
I don't understand. I was going under, couldn't see a thing with everything that was going on. I knew I was drowning, then I felt you grab me and pull me up.

Aggie shivers at the thought of her ordeal.

DYLAN
As much as I'd like to take credit for saving you, I didn't...
I couldn't. There was no way to even know what happened to you. Between the fog and the waves, it was just chaos.

AGGIE
That can't be. <u>You</u> pulled me out of the water. That's how I ended up on the deck here, alive!

Dylan shakes his head, looking down, almost embarrassed that it actually wasn't him.

Aggie looks over at the crew, eyeing each one of them for some affirmation it was one of them.

AGGIE (CONT'D)
C'mon! It had to be one of you!

Marius puts his arm around Aggie in a fatherly embrace.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Aggie, it doesn't matter. All that matters is that you're safe. If anything would have happened to you—

AGGIE
Something did happen to me!
I almost drowned in that ocean and someone... some thing... saved me!

JONAS
(to Captain Marius)
Captain, Gary and I should do some recon around the ship. Who knows what damage we took.

Jonas salutes Marius as he leaves, gives Aggie his trademark broad toothy grin. She returns the gesture the best she can in between shivers and shakes.

Gary gives Aggie an unexpected but welcome hug, then falls in behind Jonas.

FLASH
Maybe it was him.

DYLAN
Him who?
(points to the robot)
That thing?

FLASH
Yes, that thing. We left it topside and it ended up down here on the lower fishing deck. Where we found Aggie.

DYLAN
Don't be silly. It probably fell to this deck when the ship was getting tossed around. Like everything else.

Dylan points to the scattered fishing gear sprawled across the decks, in complete disarray.

Flash moves closer to the mechanical man, presses his ear to the metal body, taking notice of the electrical hum of a transformer inside.

FLASH
I know this may sound crazy, but I think this thing has somehow turned itself <u>on</u>.

INT. AGGIE'S QUARTERS - LATER

Coming out of the small shower, Aggie dries her hair, at ease for the first time since her harrowing ordeal. There's a knock on the door as she is getting dressed.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (O.S.)
Aggie? Are you dressed? May I come in?

AGGIE
Sure, give me a sec.

Aggie buttons her jeans, tosses the towel on the chair and opens the door. Marius enters the small but comfortable quarters.

AGGIE (CONT'D)
If you're here to give me all the reasons why I shouldn't be here, just turn around. I'm not in the mood.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
That's the point. I'm glad you are here. I could have lost you in that... whatever that was... whatever just happened. But you're here!

Aggie breaks down, hugs her father dearly, comforted in his strong arms.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (CONT'D)
You're safe.

Welling up with emotion, he wipes his eyes, sniffles slightly.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (CONT'D)
You must have been so frightened. All alone in that maelstrom... trying to stay alive in that frigid water...

Aggie walks over to the porthole of her cabin, glances out through the glass.

AGGIE
(in thought)
The water was warm.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Well, maybe it seemed that way with everything going on. It'd be the last thing you'd think about after going overboard like that.

AGGIE
Actually, it was the first. I knew I could probably swim or stay afloat until help came, but I knew I'd never last more than a few minutes in the cold sea.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
But... you did.

AGGIE
(stressing)
I did because the water was very... very warm. It was almost hot at a time of year when it wouldn't even be close to that temperature. In fact, it would never naturally even get that hot.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
What are you getting at?

AGGIE
I'm not sure. Remember, we are in an area we know little about.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
But the Gulf Stream is not too far from here. Maybe it shifted its current pattern. The only other thing it could be is a...

AGGIE
Volcano? More like an active seamount from some of the sonar we saw.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Sure, makes sense, especially with those weird depth readings. That's probably why the government keeps this area off-limits. It might be too dangerous to sail if it's in an active area we know nothing about.

AGGIE
It still doesn't explain how I got back on board.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
I'm fine chalking that up as a miracle and calling it a day. Believe me, I've seen enough things in my lifetime that could only be called a miracle and let's leave it at that.

AGGIE
I guess you're right but what about that mechanical man?

CAPTAIN MARIUS
What about him?

AGGIE
Why is it even here? Maybe Flash is on to something.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Whatever Flash is on—

The Callisto's warning klaxon blares, interrupting their conversation. A loud voice comes through the ship's speaker.

JONAS (O.S.)
Captain!... Captain Marius!
You're needed on the bridge!

EXT. THE CALLISTO - BRIDGE DECK - MOMENTS LATER

Jonas is standing on the outside deck of the bridge, looking through a pair of binoculars at the surrounding ocean. His face is tight with concern.

On the far side of the ship, Dylan and Flash tend to the gear, cleaning up where they can, almost tripping over the mechanical man who still lies sprawled along the side of the deck.

Marius and Aggie hurry up the stairs, notice the completely tranquil sea off the side of the boat. The stars in the night sky brightly reflect on the idyllic water.

AGGIE
This is so strange. I've never seen the ocean so still. It's like a mirror.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Yes, but after what we just went through I can't say I'm disappointed. If it stays this way by morning, we can get someone under the boat.

Jonas, fixated on something in the distance, hands Marius the binoculars without a word.

JONAS
Thirty degrees to port, about a klick.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
So far, all I see are stars, reflecting in the water. And more stars and... Wait! I think I see what it is.

JONAS
That's right. Two stars, the same exact size and brightness in the water, that aren't in the sky. What do you make of that?

CAPTAIN MARIUS
They're not stars. They're eyes.
(disconcerted)
We're being watched.

Aggie takes the binoculars, sees them too.

AGGIE
Watched? By who?

JONAS
(troubled)
The Sea Gypsies.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - LATER

For the next hour, more pairs of luminous eyes, in varying sizes and shades of blue and green, appear in the darkened water, getting closer and closer to the ship. The lights of The Callisto illuminate the waters surrounding the ship, creating what looks like a protective barrier against the encroaching eyes.

Jonas keeps careful watch from the upper deck as a slight mist rises across the surface of the sea, but the glowing eyes are still visible and bright throughout.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - CONTINUOUS

The robot lies prone on one of the fishing tables by the side of the boat, while Flash performs what can only be described as an autopsy. There are various tools and instruments displaying readings of some sort.

FLASH
(muttering to himself)
This is just unbelievable.

Flash looks at one of the meters in astonishment.

Ascending the stairs out of the engine room, on his way to the upper deck, Gary comes over to where Flash is working. His arm wound is better dressed than before.

GARY
Hey, Flash! I don't think it's a good idea to be so close to the rail. Those things seem to be getting closer all the time.

Totally immersed in his task and profound findings, Flash ignores him.

FLASH
I'll be right there. Just need to check a few more things.
(MORE)

FLASH (CONT'D)
This thing is powered on but in a suspended state and I can't get it to respond to anything. Dammit!

GARY
You still think this thing rescued Aggie?

FLASH
(still tinkering)
Somebody did, and it wasn't one of us.

The luminous eyes keeping watch over The Callisto shift color from blue and green to a deep purple.

Jonas runs out of the bridge, calls down from the deck.

JONAS
Everyone! Stay alert! Flash! Gary! Get the hell off that deck and get your asses up here NOW!

FLASH
Give me a few more minutes. I'm onto something.

JONAS
I'm not asking. That's an order, greenhorn! Move it now!

Flash and Gary make haste, packing away the instruments and tools. After the case is stowed, they run up the stairs where an angry Jonas awaits.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - BRIDGE DECK - MOMENTS LATER

JONAS
What's with you two? I got better things to do right now than babysit a bunch of "lugnuts." And leave that thing alone! We got our own damn lives to save!

Jonas points toward the surrounding sea, the mysterious eyes glowing in shades of crimson and blood-red.

GARY
That's got to be the weirdest thing I've ever seen. What do you think they are?

JONAS
Sea Gypsies, that's what they are.

GARY
Nah, that's just some fairy tale stuff to scare greenhorns.

JONAS
Sure, Gary, just a fairy tale. The same tale that cut your arm.

Gary rubs his arm, looks a bit more frightened.

JONAS (CONT'D)
Whatever they are, they're sea creatures and as long as they're in the water and we're not, then we'll be safe.

GARY
Point well taken.

The water around the ship slowly becomes a bit turbulent; the rising mist hovers over the glaring eyes of the Sea Gypsies.

JONAS
You guys keep watch. I'll check in with the Captain.

INT. THE BRIDGE - MOMENTS LATER

Jonas opens the door to the bridge, greets Aggie and Marius, who are both engaged with the displays on the computer screens in front of them. They have a look of great concern.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
So you think there's an underwater volcano erupting that's causing all of this?

AGGIE
It's the only explanation I can see right now, but it only explains one thing. Whatever else is out there—

JONAS
Excuse me, Captain. Gary and Flash are on the upper deck.

The lights of The Callisto flicker for some seconds, causing great concern across all their faces.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Well, I don't like that.
(to Jonas)
Tell Gary he better get below deck and check on the generators.

Marius stares out the window at the surrounding waters.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (CONT'D)
If we have to shift to battery power, I don't know how long the lights will stay on. For now, that seems to be the only thing keeping those... whatever they are—

JONAS
Gypsies! It's the damn SEA GYPSIES! That's whatever they are!

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Fine! The lights are the only thing keeping the... Sea Gypsies at bay.
(to Jonas)
Happy now? I said it.

JONAS
Just want to make sure we're all on the same page, that's all.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - MOMENTS LATER

Jonas hurries to the staircase leading to the lower decks.

JONAS
Gary! Gary!

Gary is already making his way down the stairs two at a time to the lower decks.

JONAS (CONT'D)
Flash! Why don't you go help Gary, see if you both can get the generators working. Without those lights, those creatures could attack the ship!

FLASH
Aye, sir!

JONAS
And Flash, no stopping by that mechanical man!

Flash nods, looks down at the deck and notices the table where the robot was lying is now empty.

FLASH
Uh, Jonas... The robot's gone.

Then Flash spots it at the bow of the ship, where the robot stands scanning the ocean that surrounds The Callisto. The eyes of the Sea Gypsies edge ever closer to the perimeter of the boat.

The robot takes notice of a particularly large group of eyes. Four brilliant white-hot lights blaze from its torso, aimed directly at the Sea Gypsies and causing them to scamper below the surface.

JONAS
Jesus! Flash? Did you turn that thing on?

FLASH
No, that's what I've been trying to tell you. It activated itself once those things—

JONAS
Sea Gypsies. Those things are the Sea Gypsies.

FLASH
Okay, Sea Gypsies, then. Somehow when those Sea Gypsies appeared, the robot turned itself on.

The robot slowly trudges over to the rail. Its optical lenses focus on the situation.

The water surrounding The Callisto churns; the boat pitches drastically.

FLASH (CONT'D)
It knows them, Jonas.

Aggie joins them on the upper deck, grabs hold of the railing.

AGGIE
Who knows who?

Flash points to the robot, calmly standing firm on the swaying bow, surveying the blood-red eyes that encroach closer and closer to the edge of The Callisto.

FLASH
He does.

The ship's bright perimeter lights shut completely off; only the dim emergency lights remain.

Without warning, the robot propels itself over the bow and into the turbulent waters below.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - CONTINUOUS

FLASH
No way! Did you see that?

Everyone watches in disbelief as the robot disappears into the gloomy abyss.

INT. THE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

The ship continues to pitch and heave in the sea as Jonas makes his way back into the bridge. Marius tries desperately to get any of the auxiliary lights working.

JONAS
Gary went below deck to see what's going on with the generators.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
I told him to make sure everything was tip-top and working! He screwed up! Big time!

JONAS
It's got to be something else. We know Gary and he's meticulous to a fault.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Well, whatever it is, without those lights working, we're in some deep trouble out here.

Marius gazes out through the windows, trying to make sense of the situation as bright lights appear underwater following the perimeter of the ship.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (CONT'D)
What the hell is that?

JONAS
It must be the robot. Somehow that thing turned itself on.

As the underwater lights continue to move back and forth around the edge of the ship, the red eyes of the Sea Gypsies scatter as the lights approach.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - CONTINUOUS

With great interest, Aggie and Flash watch the underwater lights and their effect on the Sea Gypsies.

FLASH
It must have been the robot that pulled you from the water.

AGGIE
I knew it wasn't Dylan, but how is that even possible?
Do you think it's some kind of weapon?

FLASH
Possibly... Somehow it knows when those things are around and turns itself on.

The underwater lights head toward a particularly large cluster of peering Sea Gypsy eyes when a huge volley of piercing blue electrical beams discharges from the ocean depths. An eerie glow slowly dissipates after their release.

AGGIE
That definitely does not look like a friendly greeting.

The underwater spectacle continues, with brilliant flashes of electrical energy beneath The Callisto, helpless in the water.

INT. THE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Marius bangs his fist in frustration as Gary reports over the intercom: water in the fuel.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
How could that be? The fuel tanks are sealed.

GARY (O.S.)
The only thing I could think of is we built up a ton of condensation when we were surrounded by the hot water and then the cool ocean. Diesel fuel doesn't have a vapor pressure release, so between the humidity and the low level of fuel in the tanks—

Jonas nods in agreement.

GARY (O.S.) (CONT'D)
We got water where we should have fuel.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Jesus Christ. What else can go wrong?

Marius scratches his beard in thought.

INT. ENGINE ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Thelma and Louise sputter and choke as Gary desperately fiddles with the fuel intake switches.

JONAS (O.S.)
Any chance you could separate them or filter them?

GARY
Not immediately. Water's heavier. It'll separate over time. Normally, I'd give it a day.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (O.S.)
We don't have a day.

INT. THE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Jonas looks out from the windows, paying careful attention to the bright light flashes and underwater discharges of electricity.

JONAS
I'm not sure we can wait even a few hours.

The lights of The Callisto wane, then dwindle as the last vestiges of light disappear.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - LATER

Most of the glaring Sea Gypsies have moved a safe distance from The Callisto.

The underwater light show slows significantly until a mass of Sea Gypsies charges toward the ship.

EXT. UNDERWATER - CONTINUOUS

The visibility is poor, almost nonexistent, given the turbulent waters, thick air bubbles and blazing light bursts.

The robot meets them head-on in an even greater display of underwater pyrotechnics, concentrating its efforts on the glowing eyes headed toward The Callisto.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - CONTINUOUS

The Callisto is helplessly tossed about in the rough seas, riding the waves as best she can.

EXT. UNDERWATER - CONTINUOUS

The fusillade intensifies, climaxes in an incredible final volley, then slowly dwindles down to residual flashes until everything falls silent.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - MOMENTS LATER

A state of calm falls upon The Callisto. The ocean is still.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - LOWER DECK - MOMENTS LATER

With great effort, the bruised and battered robot makes its way back to The Callisto. One of its arms is badly damaged; its servomotors strain as it desperately tries to move.

It finally reaches the lower outer deck, where it pulls itself safely aboard and out of harm's way.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - LATER

The robot is lying dormant on the table, but it's clear that it has sustained additional scarring and bruises from its recent clash with the Sea Gypsies.

Flash and Gary try to address the damage to the broken arm, referencing various electronic scopes and displays, while using delicate tools to free the servos.

FLASH
It looks like some sort of plate is jammed beneath the armature.

GARY
Yes, I see that but as soon as you poke inside there, the scope redlines. It's like there's a protective skin preventing you from going deeper.

Flash grabs a specially shaped instrument that allows him to get into the space behind the servomotor, manipulating it until the servo springs free.

FLASH
There, that should do it. See if the arm has better travel now.

Gary moves the arm back and forth, the servos moving freely.

GARY
Yeah, this looks like you did it. Nice job there.

FLASH
Thanks. That plate was jammed in there. It must've been pushed up in whatever you call the shoulder on this thing. Let's see if we can remove it entirely.

GARY
Where do you think this thing came from? Maybe it's an extraterrestrial probe or robot scout sent to the Earth. I bet that's it!

Flash reaches for a small hexagonal screwdriver, turns and loosens the screws holding the plate in place.

FLASH
Not if they're using standard 3/16-inch hex screws. This thing was made here. The question is who—

Flash works on the small screws, releasing the tension until the plate springs forward.

FLASH (CONT'D)
Oh my God! I don't believe it! Is it even possible?

GARY
Hey! Let me see what you got there.

The plate swings open, revealing intricate and complex diagrams etched on the inside of the robot.

GARY (CONT'D)
Wow! That is impressive. I've never seen anything that complex.

FLASH
What's even more impressive is this.

Flash points to a particular element from one of the diagrams.

INSERT: THE SCHEMATIC

Etched into the steel in a fine, slanted hand: a cutaway of the mechanical man, every system mapped and labeled.

TELESCOPING CAMERA LENS. HIGH-INTENSITY ARC LAMPS. TELEFORCE PARTICLE BEAM. EXTERNAL FREQUENCY MODULATOR. WARDENCLYFFE POWER GENERATOR. STABILIZER THRUSTERS.

Copper coils spiral through the arms and legs. A turbine sits where a heart would be. In the margins, column after column of equations, and the numbers 3, 6 and 9, circled again and again.

At the bottom: the name and signature NIKOLA TESLA.

BACK TO SCENE

FLASH (CONT'D)
See that name? It says it was built by "Tesla."

GARY
Well, now that makes sense. Obviously, this thing was built by Tesla as part of some new artificially intelligent droid thing.

FLASH
No, not the Tesla car company. I'm talking about Nikola Tesla. The inventor. He must have built this robot.

GARY
But Tesla died a long time ago.

FLASH
That's right. That would make this robot old. Very old. Maybe more than a hundred years old.

They both scan the schematics, assessing the details.

GARY
I've seen wiring diagrams before but these are far beyond my knowledge base. What do you make of it?

FLASH
For what it's worth, certain sections are simple and common and others are unbelievably complex, but given the universal design language of circuits, I could probably figure most of it out.

Flash pulls out his cellphone and proceeds to take photos of the drawings.

GARY
Are you sure it's okay to take photos of this thing?

FLASH
How else am I gonna have anything to study from? This is graduate school work, more like Ph.D.-level or beyond engineering. Just amazing!

GARY
Why would Tesla include these on the inside of the robot? Wouldn't you want to keep the details secret?

FLASH
That's the thing. I don't think these are the actual functionality schematics of how the robot works.

Flash continues to scan the drawings, zooming in with his cellphone and making careful notes in his own head of what they might mean.

FLASH (CONT'D)
They're directions. It's an instruction manual.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - LOWER DECK - LATER

Two battery-powered emergency work lights illuminate the table upon which the inert robot lies, dormant but with a steady buzz of electric motors and servos.

The crew walks back and forth, around all the sides of the mechanical marvel in front of them, gazing in awe at the details, curiosity abounding.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
So let me get this straight.
(to Flash)
You're telling us that this robot is about a hundred years old and was built by Nikola Tesla himself.
(scoffs)
C'mon! You can't be serious.

FLASH
I don't have to be taken seriously.
(points to the robot)
Nikki here does.

AGGIE
You named it Nikki? Very cute.

Jonas studies the features around the legs and torso.

The calf area is thick with a tapered design and closed vents. Through the pelvic area, there is a circular opening aligning from front to back, but it is in a closed position.

Across the chest is a reinforced glass aperture; four spotlights anchor the torso.

JONAS
Whatever you call it, this thing has taken a serious pounding, one way or another.

DYLAN
This looks like the find of the century. So, it turned on, just like that?

FLASH
That's the thing. It became active once those Sea Gypsies appeared. It seems to sense when they're around, like being on the same wavelength or frequency. As if they are tuned into each other.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
If it's as old as you think, where does it get its power from? There's no way batteries would last that long without needing to get recharged.

FLASH
True, but what we're looking at breaks every convention of known science. Tesla believed the Earth itself was an endless power source. Free electricity, if you knew how to tap it. However he built it, that's what's kept it alive all these years.

AGGIE
So Nikki might have been one of his experiments?

FLASH
More than an experiment. Nikki is the real deal.

Flash points to the most complex schematic.

FLASH (CONT'D)
And he wasn't alone. This diagram shows how multiple robots could be controlled, tethered, synchronized.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
How many are we talking about?

FLASH
His badge says 3-6-9, so that gives you an idea. Could be a whole army of Nikkis.

Dylan looks deep into the dormant lenses of Nikki with intrigue and wonder, and an eye for opportunity.

DYLAN
Oh, the stories you could tell behind those eyes of yours.

Abruptly, Nikki's lens apertures open, focusing directly into Dylan's eyes, startling him completely.

DYLAN (CONT'D)
Oh, crap!

Dylan jumps back, scrambling away from Nikki, as the robot powers up.

Flash takes careful notice of Nikki's startup.

FLASH
Captain Marius! I think we should be on the lookout for those Sea Gypsies.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Jonas! Head up to the bridge and see if there's any sign of those things.

JONAS
Aye, sir.
(to Gary)
Why don't you head below deck and get a status of the fuel situation for the Captain?

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Good idea. I'd like to get the hell out of here before there are any more surprises.

JONAS
I think it's too late for that.

Jonas makes his way to the stairs, where he is once again greeted by the menacing eyes of the Sea Gypsies that surround the ship. He bounds up to the bridge deck.

Mist creeps over the water, slowly roiling from within.

EXT. THE CALLISTO - ON DECK - CONTINUOUS

Marius peers over the rail, calls out as a barrage of rusted, jagged scrap metal hurtles across the open deck.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
EVERYONE! Get down! We're under attack!

The crew dives for cover, out of harm's way for now.

Nikki stands guard as the shards of steel harmlessly bounce off his metallic shell, taking careful notice of a larger presence within the assembly of Sea Gypsies to the starboard side.

The steady heartbeat-like rhythm from his first activation sharpens — brisk and precise, a different cadence entirely.

CAPTAIN MARIUS (CONT'D)
That was close! Aggie, you okay?

AGGIE
Yes! All safe here.
(calls out)
Flash? How about you?

FLASH
Fine, but Nikki's gone!
Sorry, I lost sight of him.
(beat)
But that sound he made wasn't the same as before. It was higher and faster.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Well, I'm not too surprised at that.
What about Dylan? DYLAN!... DYLAN?

They wait for a reply, but none is forthcoming.

AGGIE
I don't see him either. That's not a good sign.

CAPTAIN MARIUS
Don't worry about him.
(tries to be reassuring)
He's probably below deck, safe.

The sound of glass shattering abruptly breaks their conversation, followed by more corroded wreckage pummeling the deck.

INT. THE BRIDGE - MOMENTS LATER

Jonas ducks for cover as the protective glass implodes from the onslaught of rusted iron projectiles; deadly shards spray across the consoles.

JONAS
Oh! Hell!

EXT. THE CALLISTO - LOWER DECK - CONTINUOUS

Nikki is fully powered up; an aperture opens to reveal a propeller mounted like a bow thruster on his back. His lower legs also have marine propellers.

The benign robot has turned into a fully active weapon; crackling electricity courses through his body. His cold lenses focus on the enemy at hand. The Sea Gypsies.

(TO BE CONTINUED...)

To read the completed script of "THE SEA GYPSIES" please contact:
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